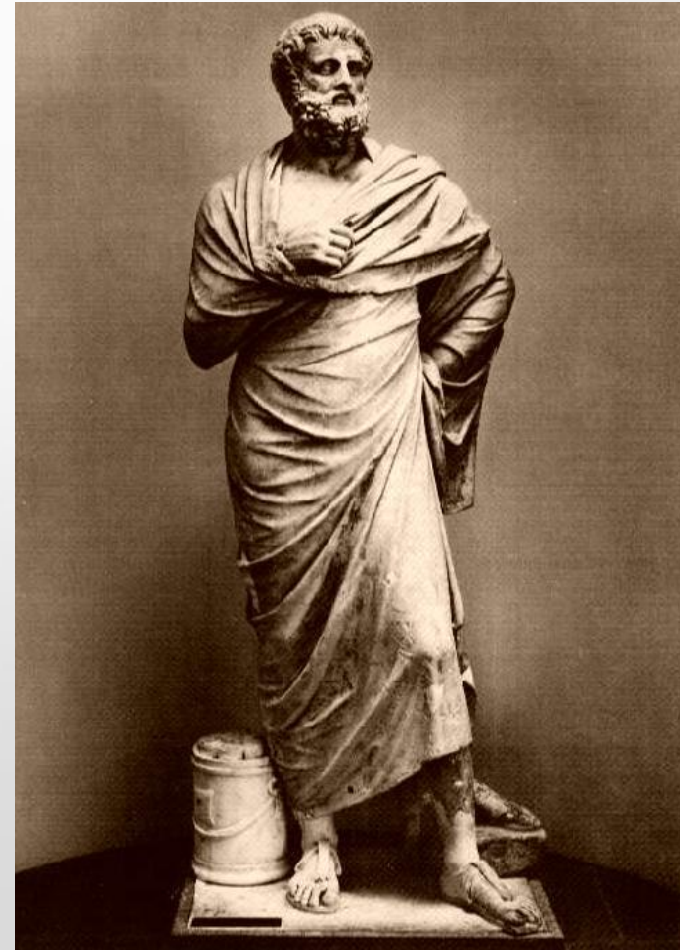
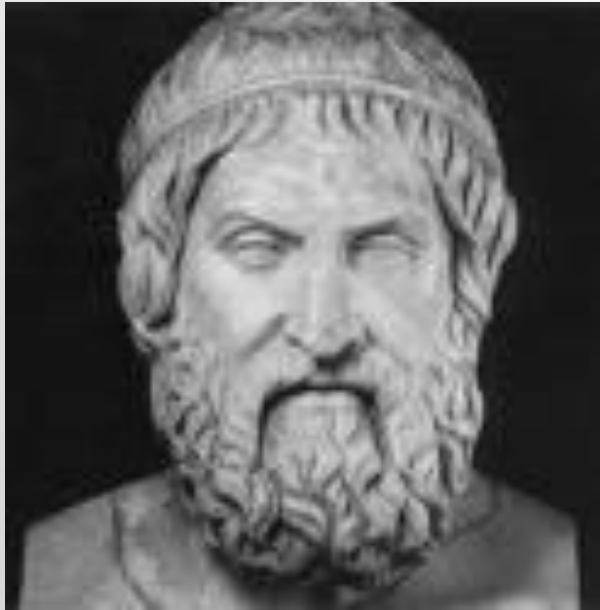


Greek Drama, Tragic Heroes, and *Oedipus Rex* by Sophocles 429 BC



Sophocles and Greek Drama

- The birth of Greek Drama:
 - Developed from ancient rituals honoring Dionysus. The celebrations became a yearly occurrence held in Athens.
- Two Types of Plays:
 - **Tragedies** are serious plays about religious or mythic questions.
 - **Satyr** plays are humorous plays about religious or mythic questions.

Review: Sophocles and Greek Drama

- The theater of Dionysus.
 - Semicircle
 - Seats carved out of stone on a hillside
 - Performance area in two parts: orchestra and skene



Sophocles and Greek Drama

- Sophocles surprised Athenians by:
 - Winning first prize for tragedy at the festival of Dionysus, beating Aeschylus.
- Who was Aeschylus?
 - The leading playwright of the time (think Steven Spielberg)
- How many tragedies did Sophocles write?
 - He wrote more than 120 tragedies... only 7 still survive today.

Sophocles and Greek Drama

- What did Sophocles write about?
 - He was concerned with the individual's need to find his/her place in the world within the existing moral/cosmic order.
 - Moral lessons against too much pride and religious indifference.
- Sophocles helped Greek drama evolve; he added:
 - A third actor (originally two- used masks)
 - Painted sets
 - Larger chorus (from 12 to 15 members)

Greek Theatre



Greek Dramatic Structure

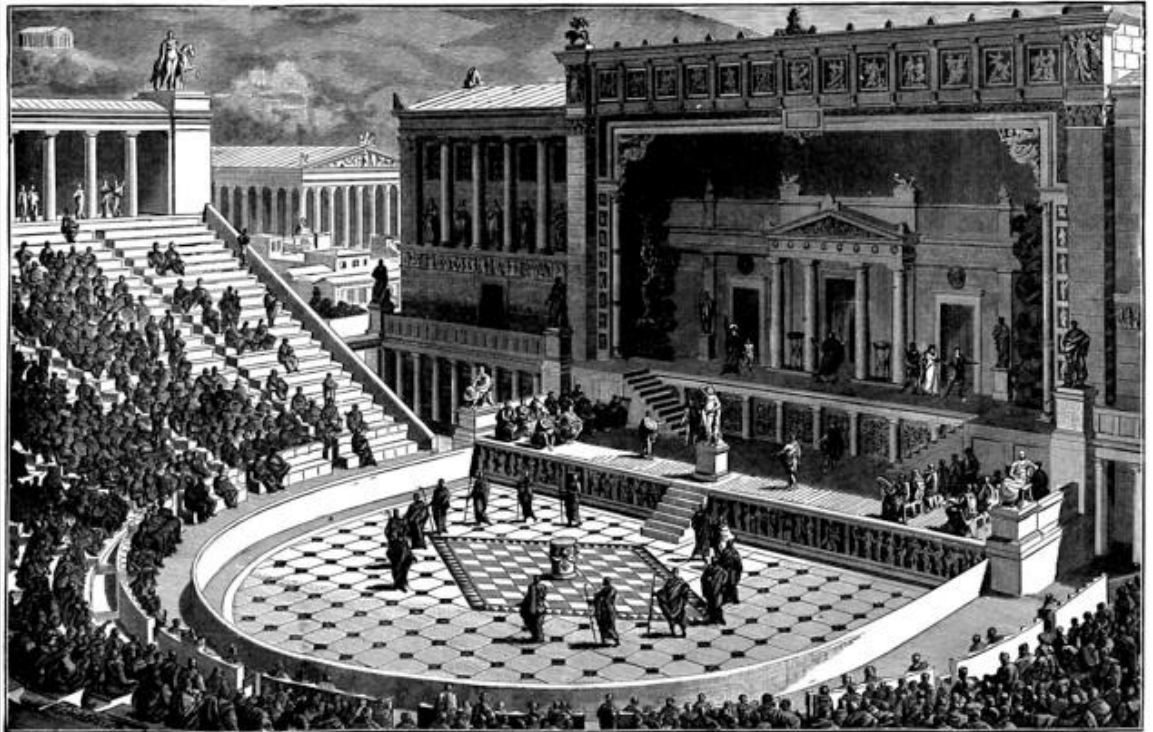
- **THE PROLOGUE (PROLOGOS):** THE **OPENING PORTION** OF THE PLAY, WHICH SETS THE SCENE AND CONTAINS THE **EXPOSITION OR BASIC SITUATION**.
- **THE PARADOS:** THE **ENTRANCE SONG** OF THE CHORUS. THE PARADOS IS NAMED AFTER THE BROAD AISLE ON EITHER SIDE OF THE THEATER, WHERE THE CHORUS **ENTERED OR EXITED**.

Greek Dramatic Structure

- **THE EPISODES (SCENES):** SCENE IN THE **ACTION** OF THE DRAMA... THE EPISODES ALTERNATE WITH THE STASIMONS (**ODES**).
- **THE STASIMONS (ODES):** A CHORAL PASSAGE, ALTERNATING WITH THE **EPISODES** OF THE PLOT OF THE DRAMA. AN ODE IS A TYPE OF **LYRIC POEM**. THE TRAGIC ODE CONSISTS OF **STROPHES** (CHANTS) AND **ANTISTROPHES** (RESPONSES) IN STANZAS OF THE POEMS. THIRD PART OF THE ODE IS THE **EPODE**.

Greek Dramatic Structure

- **EXODUS:** THE CONCLUDING SECTION OF THE TRAGEDY. THE EXODUS ENDS WITH **THE CHORUS SINGING** THEIR FINAL LINES AS THEY EXIT.



Greek Dramatic Structure

- A CLASSIC GREEK TRAGEDY CONSISTS OF:
 - PROLOGUE
 - PARADOS
 - SCENE 1 (EPISODE 1)- action
 - ODE 1 (STASIMON 1)- chorus
 - SCENE 2 (EPISODE 2) - action
 - ODE 2 (STASIMON 2) - chorus
 - SCENE 3 (EPISODE 3) - action
 - ODE 3 (STASIMON 3) - chorus
 - SCENE 4 (EPISODE 4) - action
 - ODE 4 (STASIMON 4) - chorus
 - EXODUS

Common in Greek Tragedy:

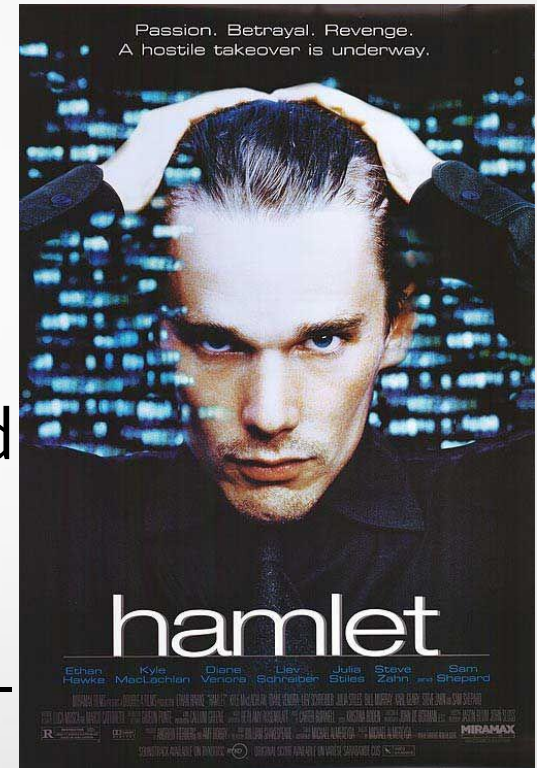
- **Dramatic irony:** When the audience knows something that the characters don't know
- **Fall of Hubris:** Hubris is excessive pride. Many tragedies deal with human pride leading to arrogant behaviors that anger the gods. Thus, man must be punished.
- **Fate vs. Freewill:** Many tragedies feature characters who try to escape unfavorable prophecies. This is futile, however, as man does not often have the power or luck to change his/her fate as determined by cosmic forces or gods/goddesses.

Characteristics of a Tragic Hero

- Must have a **fall from greatness** (either power, wealth, or social standing)
- Must be an extraordinary person, yet have a **tragic flaw**
- Tragic flaw: often a **positive character trait** that, when **taken to the extreme**, causes tragedy
- Must experience a **moment of realization** that he/she has erred
- Must **suffer greatly** due to his/her actions or flaw (often, but not always, this means death)

Tragic Hero

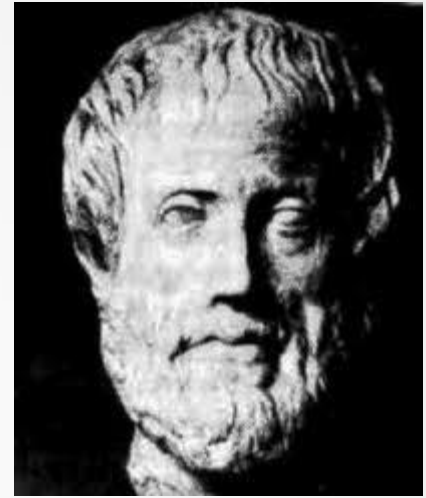
- The tragic hero is a man of noble stature.
 - “high position” usually means a king, duke, prince, company owner, etc.
- He is not an ordinary man, but a man with outstanding quality and greatness about him. (exceptions in modern literature abound)
- He is good—but not “too good”—so the audience can identify with him.



Tragic Hero

- His own destruction is for a greater cause or principle—i.e. it proves a point.
- It should be noted that the hero's downfall is his own fault as a result of his own free choice, but his misfortune is not wholly deserved.
- Usually his death is seen as a waste of human potential.

Characteristics of a Tragic Hero



According to Aristotle:

1. Traditionally of noble birth
2. **Hamartia** – a.k.a. the **tragic flaw** that eventually leads to his downfall; often this leads to a mistake in judgment.
3. **Peripeteia** – a **reversal of fortune** brought about by the hero's tragic flaw; this is often also influenced by "fate" or the gods.
4. His actions result in an increase of self- awareness and self-knowledge...though he may not choose to act on this!
5. The audience must feel pity and fear for this character.

The “tragic flaw”

- The “flaw” in the character is a defect which keeps him/her from being aware of the situation around him/her. The character does not understand (for much of the story) his/her part of creating the situation.
- Ex: Pride (“Hubris”)
 - Skywalker thinks he is so good, he can take on an experienced Jedi all by himself



Examples of Flaws

- Hubris (pride)
- Greed
- Obsession with one thing
- Mistrust
- Uncertainty
- Lack of patience
- Easily influenced
- Hesitation
- Selfishness
- Ambition

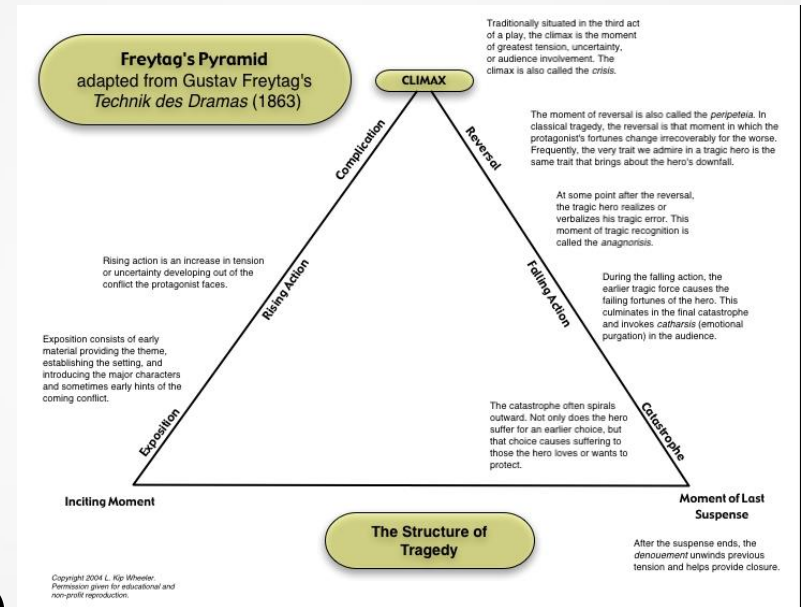


The Hero's Understanding

- **Aristotle: "A man cannot become a hero until he can see the root of his own downfall."**
- The tragic hero has a "moment of enlightenment" near the end of the story.
 - He/she finally understands what he/she has done wrong—how he/she contributed to the tragic situation.
 - The story often ends with the death of the tragic hero.
 - His death usually is not a pure loss, because it results in greater knowledge and awareness.

Shakespearean Tragic Plot

- Act I: Exposition
 - This is where the setting, characters, and conflicts are introduced.
- Act II: Rising Action
- Act III: Turning Point (Climax)
 - This is where the reversal of fortune occurs and it all starts to go badly for the tragic hero.
- Act IV: Falling Action
- Act V: Catastrophe/Resolution
 - The conflicts are resolved; chaos returns to order.



Greek Term	English Explanation
<i>hamartia</i>	Ignorance of a particular fact or set of facts. In later criticism, this was interpreted as a “tragic flaw”
<i>pathos</i>	<i>hamartia</i> + actions; tragic acts destructive to life or painful, must be combined with <i>hamartia</i>
<i>peripeteia</i>	a reversal of action/intent; where someone or something happens where the actual effect is different from the stated or intended effect
<i>anagnorisis</i>	recognition (of ignorance); the doer of <i>pathos</i> recognises that he/she has been ignorant (suffering from <i>hamartia</i>)
<i>catharsis</i>	Purification, involving regret, contrition or considerable suffering. Meaning of this word has changed over time. People use it now to mean a sense of emotional outpouring and feeling better after doing so.

Your Task: Find a Tragic Hero

- Alone or with a (1) partner, pick a tragic hero that you have seen in a film or novel.
- Fill in the chart for that character

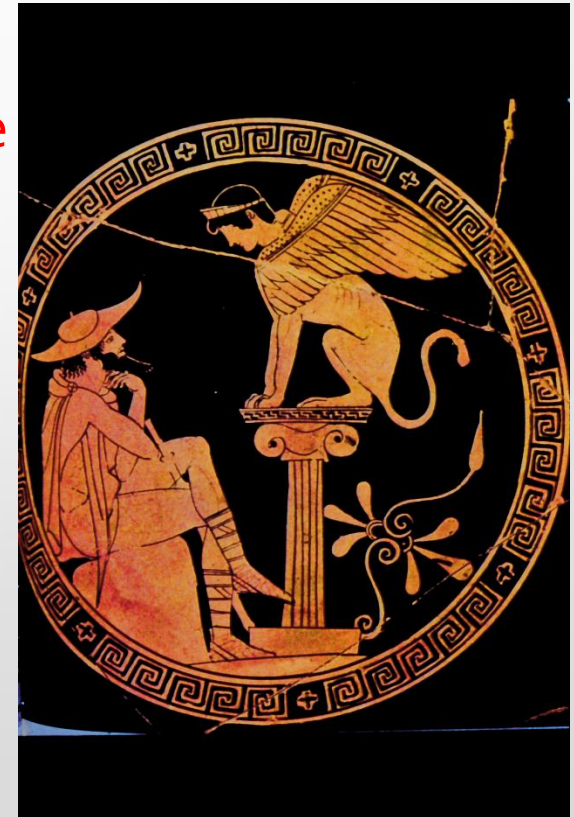
Aristotelian Tragedy in Work of your Choice

Greek Term	Brief Explanation	<u>2</u> examples
hamartia	e.g. "ignorance"	
pathos	tragic acts	
peripeteia		
anagnorisis	recognition (of ignorance)	
catharsis		

Draw up
this table
and
complete

Oedipus: King of Thebes

- Oedipus (**Swollen foot**) leaves his home city of **Corinth** because of a prophecy that he will **kill his father and marry his mother** (King and Queen of Corinth).
- During his travels, he comes upon **Thebes**, which is being terrorized by **the Sphinx**
- The Sphinx will leave the city if someone can **solve a riddle**: "What walks on four legs in the morning, two legs at noon, and three legs in the evening?"
- Oedipus answers, "**Man**". The sphinx drowns herself in defeat. Thebes is saved!



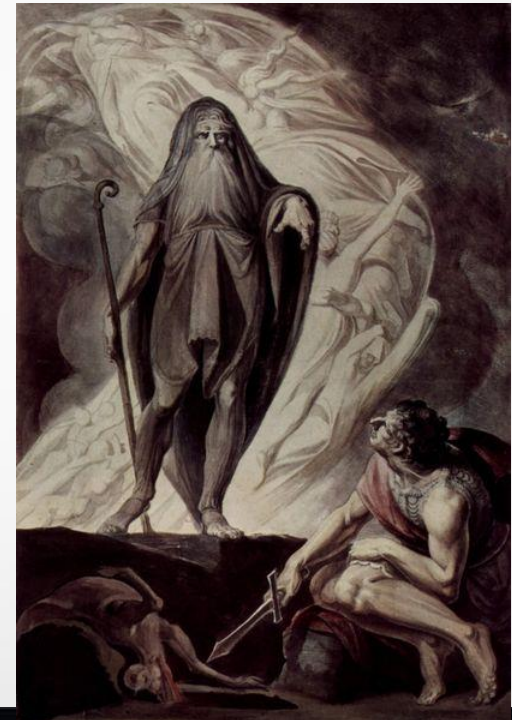
Oedipus: King of Thebes



- Oedipus becomes the king and marries **Jocasta**, the queen
- The former Theban king, **Laius**, was previously murdered
- As the play opens, Thebes is suffering a **terrible plague** because Laius' death has **not been avenged**

Oedipus Rex: Characters

- Oedipus- King of Thebes
- Jocasta- Queen of Thebes
- **Creon**- Jocasta's brother; acted as king when Laius was murdered
- **Tiresias**- blind prophet
- Messenger from Corinth (city that Oedipus is originally from)
- Shepherd
- **Antigone and Ismene**- Oedipus and Jocasta's daughters
- Chorus and Chorus leader (**Choragus**) - act as the "voices of society"



Aristotelian Tragedy in *Oedipus Rex*

Greek Term	Brief Explanation	<u>Oedipus the King</u> examples
hamartia	e.g. "ignorance"	(Must include at least 2 quotes with explanation for each)
pathos	tragic acts	
peripeteia		
anagnorisis		
catharsis		

Draw up
this table
and
complete